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Credit - Drishti Ias

Adaptation Gap Report 2026

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For Prelims: Adaptation , Nationally Determined Contributions , National Adaptation Plans , Glasgow Climate Pact , Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage , Paris Agreement ,

For Mains: Adaptation vs. Mitigation , Energy Transition, **Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage , Paris Agreement .**

Source: DD

Why in News?

The **United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP)** has released the **Adaptation Gap Report 2026** , titled **" *Ready? Not. Climate impacts will not wait. Adaptation finance must rise.*"** The report warns that **adaptation finance** continues to fall far short of needs, implementation is constrained by institutional barriers, and loss and damage are mounting as climate impacts intensify.

Summary

- The UNEP Adaptation Gap Report 2026 highlights the widening gap between climate adaptation needs and available finance, with developing countries facing rising debt burdens and climate-related losses.
- It calls for predictable, grant-based climate finance, stronger support for the Loss and Damage Fund, and climate justice based on CBDR-RC.

What are the Key Highlights of the Adaptation Gap Report 2026?

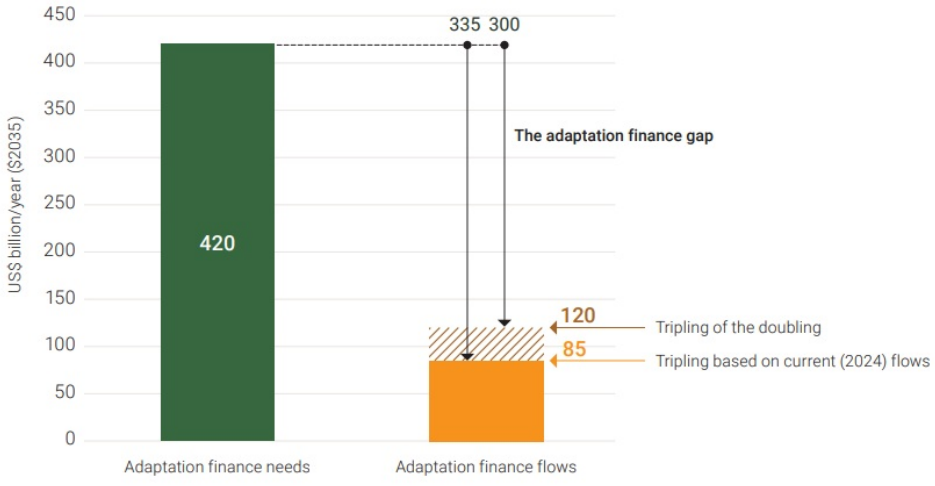
The Adaptation Finance Deficit

- **Estimated Needs:** Based on the latest **Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) and National**

Adaptation Plans (NAPs) **of 155 developing countries,** climate adaptation finance needs are estimated at USD 255–328 billion annually over the next decade, reaching around **USD 305 billion per year by 2035.** Including private-sector needs could nearly double the requirement.

  - Least Developed Countries (LDCs) and Small Island Developing States (SIDS) require USD 40–50 billion annually for climate adaptation, equivalent to **3–4% of their GDP,** nearly twice the relative needs of upper-middle-income developing countries.

- **Current Flows:** International public adaptation finance reached USD **28.2 - 31.7 billion in 2024,** falling short of the trajectory needed to meet the **Glasgow Climate Pact target.**
  - **Glasgow Climate Pact (COP26, 2021)** urged developed countries to at least double adaptation finance from 2019 levels by 2025 (about USD 40 billion).
  - The report notes that the **2025 target remains achievable** , provided adequate funding is mobilised through Multilateral Development Banks (MDBs) and bilateral development flows.
- **Rising Debt Burden:** While 80–90% of funding for LDCs and SIDS is concessional, **55% of all adaptation finance to developing countries in 2024 was delivered as loans.**
  - Non-concessional loans account for approximately half of all adaptation lending, mainly provided by MDBs to middle-income countries
- **The "Tripling" Shortfall:** The COP30 proposal to triple adaptation finance by 2035 would **yield USD 85-120 billion annually.**
  - Adjusted for inflation, 2035 needs rise from USD 305 billion to **USD 420 billion** , so tripling would meet only **20–29% of needs** , leaving a gap of roughly **USD 300–335 billion** .
- **South-South Cooperation:** Financial support between developing nations is actively growing, jumping from USD 3.8 billion in 2019 to USD 9.6 billion in 2024.
- **Limits of Private Adaptation Finance:** Private finance mobilised through international public adaptation finance doubled from **USD 1.5 billion in 2019 to USD 3 billion in 2024.**
  - However, private finance may bridge only **15–20% of the financing gap for public-oriented adaptation needs,** underscoring the continued importance of public finance.
- **Effective Adaptation:** The report notes that the adaptation implementation requires more than finance. It depends on **eight institutional factors,** including clear legal frameworks, defined mandates, intergovernmental coordination, stakeholder participation, accountability, knowledge-sharing, and effective finance mobilisation, alongside addressing legacy dependencies.

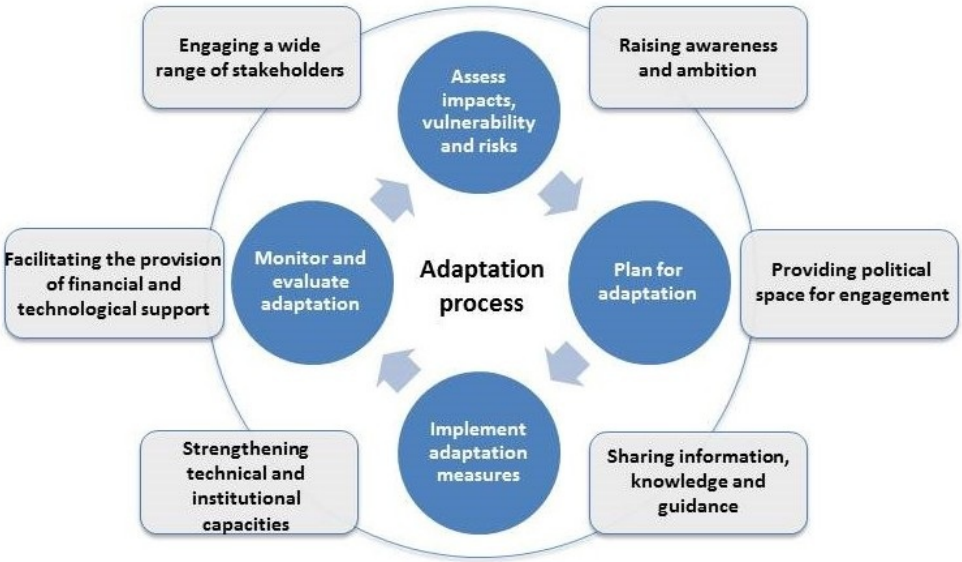


Loss and Damage (L&D)

- **Disproportionate Impact:** Between 2020 and 2025, 99% of the 765 million people affected by floods and landslides lived in low- and middle-income countries.
- **The Data Gap:** Among 118 countries assessed, 89% recognise **Loss and Damage (L&D)** in their NDCs or NAPs, 54% have information systems to track it and 38% have relevant legal frameworks
  - Only 27% of nearly 240,000 recorded extreme-heat deaths during 2020–2025 were reported in lower-income countries, potentially reflecting underreporting, limited observation capacity and differences in preparedness.
  - This severely masks non-economic losses like cultural heritage, mental health, and biodiversity degradation.
- **Severe Funding Shortfall:** 119 developing countries sought USD 2.8 billion from the **United Nations' Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD),** far exceeding its initial funding envelope of USD 342 million.

What is Climate Adaptation?

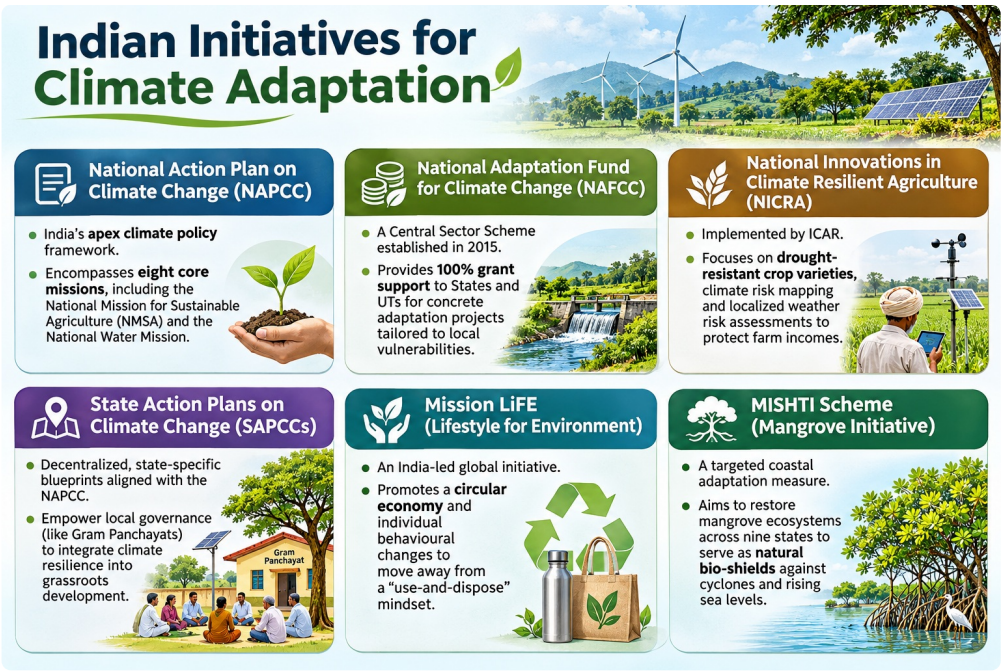
- **About:** Adaptation refers to adjustments in **ecological, social or economic systems** in response to actual or expected climatic stimuli and their effects.
  - It refers to changes in processes, practices and structures to moderate **potential damages or to benefit from opportunities associated with climate change.**



- **Global Adaptation Mechanisms under UNFCCC:**
  - **Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA):** Established under **Article 7.1 of the Paris Agreement** , the **GGA** is a collective global commitment designed to enhance adaptive capacity, strengthen systemic resilience, and reduce macroeconomic vulnerability to climate impacts.
  - **Least Developed Countries Expert Group (LEG):** Established in 2001, LEG is mandated to provide technical guidance and financial support to vulnerable nations for formulating and implementing **NAPs** .
  - **Adaptation Committee (AC):** Established in 2010, the AC acts as the **apex global voice** on adaptation, providing expert technical guidance to ensure coherent worldwide implementation of the **Paris Agreement** .
  - **Nairobi Work Programme (NWP):** Operates the **Adaptation Knowledge Portal** , serving as the central knowledge-to-action hub for identifying global climate vulnerabilities and sharing resilience

strategies.

- **India's Stance on Climate Adaptation:**
  - **Climate Justice & CBDR-RC:** India anchors its position on **Common But Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities** , demanding that developed nations provide predictable, highly concessional, and publicly funded climate finance.
  - **Voluntary GGA Indicators:** India maintains that performance indicators under the GGA must remain voluntary, country-driven, and non-prescriptive, opposing their use as **conditions for accessing multilateral climate finance.**



Click here to Read: **Blueprint for India's Climate Adaptation**

What Measures are Needed to Strengthen Global Climate Adaptation?

- **Integrate with NCQG Framework:** Embed robust adaptation tracking mechanisms within the **New Collective Quantified Goal (NCQG)** to ensure the transparent mobilization of private capital, moving beyond the unfulfilled ambitions of the **Glasgow Climate Pact** .
- **Restructure MDB Lending:** Reform the lending architecture of **Multilateral Development Banks (MDBs)** to prioritize grant-based, highly concessional financing for the Global South, thereby preventing **climate-driven sovereign debt crises.**
- **Recapitalize the L&D Fund:** Simplify operational access to the **FRLD** to address severe capitalization shortfalls and meet the immediate needs of vulnerable nations.
  - Mandate the creation of dedicated national **Loss and Damage Information Systems** to systematically quantify cascading systemic risks and evaluate critical **non-economic losses** , such as cultural heritage and biodiversity degradation.
- **Decentralized Domestic Mainstreaming:** Strengthen grassroots resilience by aligning apex national policies like the **National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC)** with decentralized **State Action Plans on Climate Change (SAPCCs)** , specifically prioritizing the protection of agrarian economies and coastal ecosystems.

- **Address Institutional Deficits:** Strengthen legal mandates, intergovernmental coordination, community participation and independent monitoring mechanisms to translate adaptation plans into effective implementation.

Conclusion

Addressing climate impacts requires predictable, grant-based adaptation finance, stronger funding under the New Collective Quantified Goal, and recapitalisation of the Loss and Damage Fund. Upholding climate justice and CBDR-RC is vital to building resilience across the Global South.

> ***Drishti Mains Question:***
>
> The widening climate adaptation finance gap reflects not merely a shortage of resources but also inequalities in the global climate governance framework. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the UNEP Adaptation Gap Report 2026?
It assesses the gap between developing countries' climate adaptation needs and available finance, highlighting challenges in implementation and loss and damage.

2. What is the estimated global adaptation finance requirement by 2035?
Developing countries require around US$305 billion annually, rising to approximately US$420 billion in 2035 prices.

3. What is the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA)?
Established under Article 7.1 of the Paris Agreement, the GGA aims to enhance adaptive capacity, strengthen resilience and reduce vulnerability to climate change.

4. What is the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD)?
It is a climate finance mechanism established to assist vulnerable developing countries in addressing economic and non-economic losses caused by climate change.

5. What is India's position on climate adaptation finance?
India advocates climate justice and CBDR-RC, demanding predictable, publicly funded and highly concessional climate finance from developed countries.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/ffUixFyINZ0**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q.1 In the context of India’s preparation for Climate-Smart Agriculture, consider the following statements: (2021)

1. The ‘Climate-Smart Village’ approach in India is a part of a project led by the Climate Change, Agriculture and Food Security (CCAFS), an international research programme.
2. The project of CCAFS is carried out under Consultative Group on International Agricultural Research (CGIAR) headquartered in France.

3. The International Crops Research Institute for the Semi-Arid Tropics (ICRISAT) in India is one of the CGIAR's research centres.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (d)

Q.2 Which of the following best describes/describe the aim of 'Green India Mission' of the Government of India? (2016)

1. Incorporating environmental benefits and costs into the Union and State Budgets thereby implementing the 'green accounting'.
2. Launching the second green revolution to enhance agricultural output so as to ensure food security to one and all in the future.
3. Restoring and enhancing forest cover and responding to climate change by a combination of adaptation and mitigation measures.

Select the correct answer using the code given below.

(a) 1 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (c)

Q.3 With reference to 'Global Climate Change Alliance', which of the following statements is/are correct? (2017)

1. It is an initiative of the European Union.
2. It provides technical and financial support to targeted developing countries to integrate climate change into their development policies and budgets.
3. It is coordinated by World Resources Institute (WRI) and World Business Council for Sustainable Development (WBCSD).

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 3 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q.1 Describe the major outcomes of the 26th session of the Conference of the Parties (COP) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). What are the commitments made by India in this conference? **(2021)**

Q.2 'Climate Change' is a global problem. How will India be affected by climate change? How Himalayan and coastal states of India will be affected by climate change? **(2017)**

Immigration and Foreigners (Exemption) Amendment Order, 2026

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Source: TH

The **Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA)** notified the Immigration and **Foreigners (Exemption) (Amendment) Order, 2026** , revising passport and visa exemptions for specified foreign nationals, including religious minorities from **Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan, Tibetan refugees, Sri Lankan Tamils** and certain long-term foreign residents.

- **Legal Framework:** The amendment modifies the **Immigration and Foreigners (Exemption) Order, 2025** , issued under the **Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025.**
- **Visa Requirement for Religious Minorities:** Applies to **Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and Christians from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan** who entered India on or before 31st December 2024 due to religious persecution or fear of such persecution.
  - The exemption from possessing valid passports or visas at the time of entry is retained, but an appropriate category of visa is now mandatory for continued stay in India.
- **Visa Manual:** Formally defines the **Visa Manual as instructions issued by the Central Government concerning visas, immigration and related matters** .
- **Travel Between India, Nepal and Bhutan:**
  - Indian, Nepali and Bhutanese citizens travelling between these countries must produce identity documents prescribed in the Visa Manual before immigration authorities.
  - Indian citizens travelling to or returning from third countries through Nepal or Bhutan must possess valid passports and use designated immigration posts.
  - Nepali and Bhutanese citizens entering or exiting India from/to countries other than Nepal or Bhutan require valid passports. Those arriving after embarkation or transit through **China, Macau, Hong Kong or Pakistan** require both valid passports and visas.
- **Tibetan Refugees:** Retains passport and visa exemptions for Tibetans who entered **India after 1959 with an Entry Permit (before 30th May 2003)** or a Special Entry Permit (thereafter), subject to prescribed registration requirements.
- **Sri Lankan Tamil Refugees:** Registered Sri Lankan Tamil nationals **who took shelter in India up to 9th January 2015** remain exempt from specified passport and visa requirements for entry, stay and exit, subject to registration with designated Central or State Government officers.
- **Other Exempted Categories:** Includes specified military personnel, long-term Pakistani residents, Partition-era migrants and certain persons of Indian origin facing passport-renewal difficulties, subject to applicable conditions.

Difference Between the 2026 Amendment and CAA, 2019

Basis	2026 Amendment Order	Citizenship (Amendment) Act, 2019
Purpose	Regulates entry exemptions and visa requirements for continued stay	Provides a special pathway to Indian citizenship
Cut-off Date	31st December 2024	31st December 2014
Communities	Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and Christians	Same six communities
Countries	Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan	Same three countries
Legal Effect	Requires an appropriate visa for continued stay while retaining specified exemptions	Facilitates citizenship subject to statutory eligibility conditions

Read More: Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025

India Announces $500 Million Line of Credit for Guyana

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Source: DD

India announced a **USD 500 million Line of Credit (LoC) for road infrastructure, healthcare and defence projects in Guyana** on the sidelines of the **Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting (CHOGM) 2026 in Antigua and Barbuda.**

- **Development Financing:** The **USD 500 million LoC will support Guyana's infrastructure and development priorities,** building on cooperation following the **Indian Prime Minister's visit in November 2024.**
  - A Line of Credit (LoC) is a financing arrangement that enables a partner country to access funds for agreed projects, generally under specified repayment conditions.
- **Three Bilateral Agreements:**
  - **Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs):** Supply and installation of manufacturing projects to promote

entrepreneurship and employment.

- **Quick Impact Projects (QIPs):** Indian grant assistance for community-level development initiatives.
- **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI):** Cooperation to establish a UPI-like digital payment system in Guyana, with Indian technical support.

- **Digital Cooperation:** Guyana aims to launch the **UPI- like payment system** by the end of 2026, with over 20 Guyanese personnel expected to receive training in India's UPI ecosystem.
- **Broader Partnership:** Both countries reviewed cooperation in **trade, energy, agriculture, infrastructure and capacity-building,** reflecting their shared priorities as Commonwealth members and Global South partners.
- **Strategic Importance:** Guyana's expanding offshore petroleum sector and its position within CARICOM make it an important partner for **India's engagement with the Caribbean and the Global South.**

Guyana

- **Location:** Guyana is situated on the northern coast of South America, bordered by **Venezuela (west), Brazil (south), Suriname (east) and the Atlantic Ocean (north).**
- **Capital and Official Language: Georgetown is the capital, and English is the official language,** making Guyana the only South American country with English as its official language.
- **Membership:** Member of the **Commonwealth of Nations** and the **Caribbean Community (CARICOM)** .



Read More: PM's Visit to Nigeria, Brazil and Guyana

NASA's Swift Space Telescope Re-enters Earth's Atmosphere

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Source: DD

NASA's Neil Gehrels Swift Observatory , a space telescope dedicated to studying **gamma-ray bursts (GRBs) and other high-energy cosmic phenomena,** re-entered Earth's atmosphere over North Sumatra, Indonesia, on 4th November 2026, ending its 22-year mission.

- **Atmospheric Re-entry:** The **approximately 1,452-kg satellite re-entered Earth's atmosphere at around 22 times the speed of sound** , with most of its structure expected to burn up due to atmospheric heating.
- NASA reported no injuries or damage from falling debris.
- **Mission Background:** Launched in **2004, the observatory was designed for a two-year mission but remained operational for nearly 22 years** , ceasing scientific operations on 20th October 2026.
- **Primary Objective:** To detect and study gamma-ray bursts, among the most energetic explosions in the universe, using observations across multiple wavelengths. Swift could **rapidly redirect its telescopes within about a minute** to observe the fading afterglows of gamma-ray bursts.
- **Scientific Instruments:** Swift carried three complementary telescopes:
  - **Burst Alert Telescope (BAT):** Detects gamma-ray bursts and determines their approximate locations.
  - **X-Ray Telescope (XRT):** Observes X-ray emissions and afterglows associated with cosmic explosions.
  - **Ultraviolet/Optical Telescope (UVOT):** Studies ultraviolet and visible-light emissions from astronomical sources.
- **Scientific Contributions:** Swift observed over **2,000 gamma-ray bursts and 1,400 supernovae, alongside black holes, stellar X-ray flares, asteroids and comets,** contributing to approximately 7,000 scientific publications.
- **Unsuccessful Orbit-Raising Attempt: Katalyst Space launched the LINK spacecraft in July 2026,** under a NASA-funded mission to capture Swift and raise its orbit.
  - However, propulsion and attitude-control failures prevented the planned orbital adjustment.
- **Cause of Re-entry:** Swift lacked an onboard propulsion system to maintain or raise its orbit, making it vulnerable to gradual orbital decay caused by atmospheric drag.



Read More: NASA Invites ISRO to Join Moon Base Programme

CERT-In Artificial Intelligence Security Auditing Guidelines

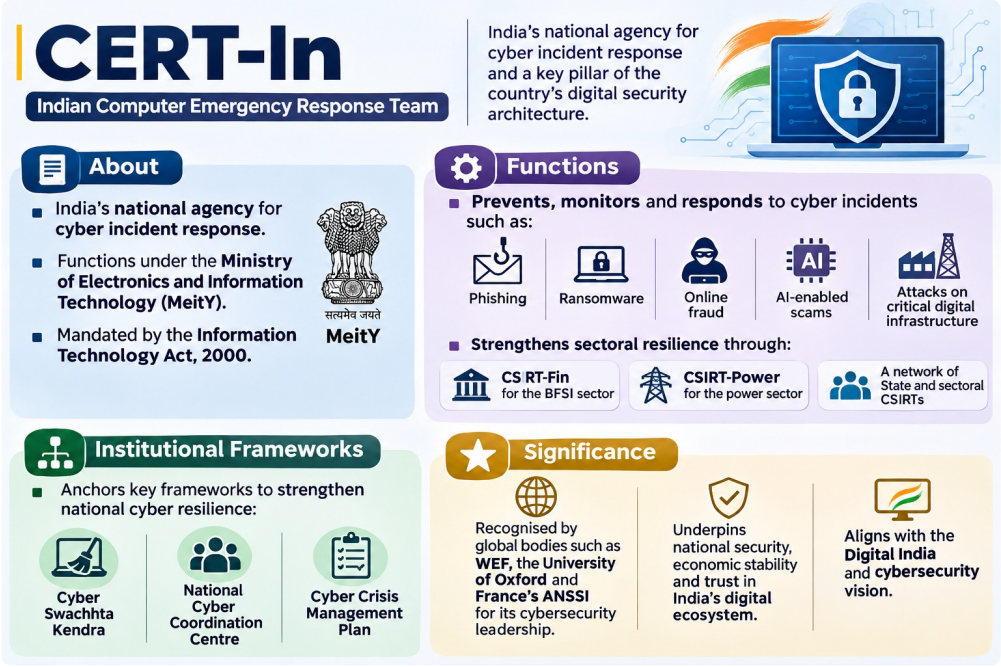
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Source:TH

The **Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In)** has issued **the "Artificial Intelligence (AI) Security Auditing Guidelines,"** establishing a comprehensive framework to regulate, monitor, and audit the emerging risks associated with **agentic AI systems** and their autonomous capabilities.

- **Defining Agentic AI:** Unlike traditional Generative AI, which primarily responds to user prompts with text, images, or code, Agentic AI refers to autonomous artificial intelligence systems capable of taking independent actions to achieve designated goals.
  - These "agents" can interact with other software, execute commands, browse the internet, and manipulate files with minimal human intervention.
- **CERT-In's AI Security Auditing Guidelines:**
  - **Risk-Tiering System:** The guidelines classifies AI systems into **four risk tiers (Low, Moderate, High, and Critical)** based on impact severity, data sensitivity, and decision-making autonomy, which dictates the required depth, frequency, and independence of the audit.
  - **Comprehensive Audit Domains:** Encompasses **nine core domains** covering the entire AI lifecycle, prominently including **AI Governance, Data Privacy, Model Risk Management, Bias and Fairness, Explainability, Continuous Monitoring, Human Oversight and Supply-Chain Assurance.**
  - **Emerging Tech Safeguards:** Mandates dedicated security protocols for advanced architectures like **Generative AI, Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG),** and **Agentic AI** to proactively mitigate critical threats like prompt injection, data/model poisoning, and misinformation.

- **Human-in-the-Loop:** While AI-assisted audit procedures are permitted for evidence analysis, they are strictly subject to confidentiality controls, tool validation, and competent human review.
  - AI outputs **cannot replace an auditor's independent judgment** .
- **Strategic Alignment:** The guidelines are highly interoperable, aligning with **MeitY's India AI Governance Guidelines under 2025, under the IndiaAI Mission** , and global standards like **ISO/IEC 42001** .
  - ISO/IEC 42001, published in 2023, is the world's first international standard for an **Artificial Intelligence Management System (AIMS),** jointly developed by the **International Organization for Standardization (ISO) and the International Electrotechnical Commission (IEC)** .
- **Seven Guiding Principles:** The foundation of the framework rests on principles vital to India's digital policy: **Security-by-Design, Accountability and Human Oversight, Transparency, Fairness, Data Privacy, and Auditability.**



Read more: **India's Blueprint for AI Regulation**

Centre to Set Up Panel to Review UGC Equity Regulations, 2026

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Source: TH

The Central Government is contemplating setting up a special committee **to re-evaluate** the **University Grants Commission (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026** , aiming to create a neutral framework that protects all students from discrimination.

- **Background:** The 2026 Regulations were formulated in response to the ongoing case ***Abeda Salim Tadvi v. Union of India (2019),*** which seeks to establish a mechanism to end caste-based discrimination on campuses.
- **Judicial Stay on 2026 Rules:** Following nationwide protests and legal challenges from various student groups, the **Supreme Court stayed the 2026 regulations** in January due to concerns over **vague provisions and possible misuse** , temporarily restoring the older **2012 framework** .
- **UGC Equity Regulations, 2026:** The regulations aimed to eradicate discrimination on the basis of religion, race, caste, sex, or place of birth, and to promote equity and inclusion, particularly for **Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs), Socially and Educationally Backward Classes (SEBCs), and Economically Weaker Sections (EWS).**
  - **Key Provisions:**
    - **Institutional Mechanisms:** HEIs are required to establish an **Equal Opportunity Centre** and appoint an Ombudsperson to handle escalated grievances.
    - **Surveillance and Support:** The rules mandate the creation of an **Equity Helpline** .
      - They also proposed the formation of **mobile 'Equity Squads'** to monitor vulnerable spots on campuses and the designation of 'Equity Ambassadors' among stakeholders.
    - **Stricter Penalties:** The regulations provide for severe financial penalties and the potential withdrawal of UGC grants for institutions that fail to **comply with equity standards or ignore complaints of discrimination.**
- **Concerns:**
  - **Exclusion of General Category Students:** A primary objection to the regulations is that the grievance redressal mechanism **allegedly excludes general-category students.**
    - Critics argue this leaves non-reserved students without adequate recourse if they face discrimination or harassment.
  - **Potential Misuse** : The final regulations omitted a draft provision prescribing penalties for false discrimination complaints, prompting concerns about misuse and procedural fairness.
  - **Segregation and Fraternity:** The Court questioned whether separate arrangements in hostels, classrooms or mentorship groups could reinforce a **“separate but equal” framework, contrary to Articles 14 and 15 and constitutional fraternity.**
    - The Court emphasized that an anti-discrimination framework should not end up making any one section feel disadvantaged.
  - **Sub-classification Concerns:** The Court also questioned if the new rules adequately protect **Extremely Backward Castes** within the existing statutory sub-classification of SCs, STs, and OBCs against structural disadvantages.
  - **Omission of Ragging:** The Court also raised concerns about the absence of ragging as an explicitly recognised form of discrimination and its potential implications for **Articles 14 and 21.**

Read more: **Supreme Court Stays UGC's 2026 Regulations**